



MONTHLY UPDATE

Namibia: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-25 · 57 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

The electronic identity card moved from announcement into a dated rollout. Officials confirmed on 25 July that issuance begins in September 2026, that existing documents stay valid until a gazette notice withdraws them, and that first-time applicants receive a randomly generated number ([ministry account](#)); on 28 July the ministry confirmed the card is free for first-time applicants, renewals of expired cards and amendments ([costs account](#)).

The payments layer published its first full account of itself. The central bank confirmed the instant payment solution became operational in June 2026 with three participating institutions ([central bank account](#)), and an association report released on 28 July recorded a national quick-response standard finalised, open banking specifications complete and the interbank settlement system migrated to an international messaging standard ([report account](#)).

An opposition member asked parliament on 4 August to compel disclosure of the Chinese smart-city agreements and to pass a data protection act before the build ([member's account](#)).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The ICT minister met a consultancy delegation in Windhoek on 3 August on trustworthy artificial intelligence, broadband access, cybersecurity, data centres, clean energy and women in technology, and stated that consultations on the strategy framework had already begun under the research council and that government has prioritised a strategy before introducing legislation ([ministerial account](#)). No contract, terms of reference or procurement route involving the consultancy is established ([second account](#)).

Legislation and regulation

The ICT minister told the regulator's new board on 13 July that the Cybercrime Bill and the Data Protection Bill were being finalised, and the ministry stated that Namibia is still developing a comprehensive legislative framework for cybercrime, with law enforcement and the judiciary relying meanwhile on the Electronic Transactions Act, the Communications Act and the penal code ([board account](#)).

Data protection

On 4 August an opposition member told a newspaper that with no data-protection statute in force there is no legal definition of a data controller and no rules governing cross-border transfer, that the constitutional privacy provision has no enabling statute, and asked parliament to compel disclosure of the smart-city agreements, annexures, contractors, data architecture and lifetime operating costs ([member's account](#)). A gazette notice withdrawing existing identity documents is otherwise covered in this month's summary; it has no separate drafted narrative here.

Regional collaboration

Cabinet approved a memorandum on information technology cooperation with the Republic of Congo at its 22nd and 23rd sittings and authorised the minister to sign, publishing no scope, sector detail, financing or signature date ([cabinet account](#)).

Namibia joined four other governments as a founding partner of a pan-African African-language artificial-intelligence initiative launched at a continental telecommunications conference in Abuja on 24 July ([launch account](#)). Namibia's stated commitment is ministerial support rather than a named contribution, and the ICT minister is one of eight Africans on a 44-member international commission ([conference account](#)).

The memorandum with Botswana was signed. The two ICT ministries, with their operators and regulators, [signed at Kasane on 7 August, covering digital transformation, cybersecurity, connectivity and skills development](#), and published operational detail alongside it: [the Trans-Kalahari Corridor's remaining 4G gaps costed at about N\\$52 million across 13 new sites, and the Gobabis-Buitepos fibre link completed and interconnecting with the Botswana backbone company at Charles Hill](#) — the first direct cross-border fibre link between the two operators — with the two incident-response teams said to be deepening cooperation. The signed instrument itself is not held, and no term, funding or data-governance provision is published.

India is the other bilateral track. At the [fourth joint trade committee in New Delhi on 12 August the two governments advanced cybersecurity and digital-economy cooperation](#), building on a memorandum the two heads of government signed in July 2025 and against bilateral trade put at more than US\$592m in 2025/26. That memorandum's text is not held either.

The regulator also took the chair of something. The southern African regulators' association [opened the first meeting of its legal and policy committee at Windhoek from 10 to 12 August, with artificial-intelligence governance, data governance and protection, digital public infrastructure and regulatory harmonisation on the agenda](#). No work programme, output or timetable is published with it.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

On 30 July the ministry, the regulator and three operators met the traditional authorities' trust on streamlining tower siting and cutting deployment delays and costs; the ministry reported no agreement, instrument or timetable ([convening account](#)). Traditional authorities manage communal land, which the ministry treats as the siting constraint.

Data Storage

A vendor is building smart-city solutions and a data centre with the ICT and home affairs ministries, and [China committed CNY 98,000,000, given as about US\\$14.4m](#). No signed agreement, annexure or contractor list is held, and an [opposition member puts the same commitment at N\\$245m](#) with no dated conversion between the two.

Cybersecurity

The regulator recorded 513,921 vulnerabilities and 161,547 cyber events between April and June 2026, up 39.8% and 56.7% on the prior quarter, and attributed the rise to systems needlessly reachable from the internet, unpatched software and weak authentication ([regulator account](#)). The figures come a quarter after incident management guidelines were issued in April 2026.

The regulator and the chamber of commerce signed a three-year memorandum in Windhoek on 30 July with a joint steering committee, covering public key infrastructure, cybersecurity, electronic trade facilitation, regulatory standards, legislative reform, digital literacy and capacity building; no funding, deliverables or milestones were published ([memorandum account](#)). The regulator separately stated on 29 July that it is the national root certification authority.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

The identity ministry reported on 23 July that it printed 166,237 identity documents between 1 April 2025 and 30 June 2026 of which 125,999 were collected, leaving 40,238 uncollected, and that a school registration drive had reached 24 of 55 target schools ([ministry figures](#)).

The regional outreach opened in Omaheke on 27 July and ran to 5 August across all seven constituencies, delivered with a development agency and the regulator ([outreach account](#)). The regional governor said marginalised communities need to be convinced to take up the card, and the ministry team named low literacy as the obstacle to understanding it ([governor's account](#)).

Alongside the outreach runs a [Youth e-ID Ambassadors Programme, using young people to promote take-up of the credential and civic participation](#). Participant numbers, cost, duration and any effect on enrolment are unstated, and the funding agency's own account is the only one the base holds.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The central bank, the instant payments company and the clearing house signed a declaration of intent on 2 July to integrate instant payments with the national clearing infrastructure, publishing no deliverables, funding or timetable ([declaration account](#)).

The payments association's annual general meeting on 28 July also heard that licensing and supervision of payment providers will move to the central bank, with no instrument, commencement date or transition plan published ([central bank account](#)).

Registries

The business and intellectual property authority [offers online name search, name reservation and application-status verification](#), with no transaction or uptake figure published and no publication date on the capture. The civil registration statute is unchanged and was [read by officials on 25 July as permitting institutions to accept either the physical card or its digital version, with disclosure conditional on the holder's consent](#). Its commencement date is not established and the held record summarises rather than reproduces it.

Sectoral management information systems

The health ministry held national training at Swakopmund in the week to 29 July for a mobile application replacing community health workers' paper registers; no rollout date was announced and paper and digital are to run in parallel ([training account](#)).

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Legally recognised electronic signatures have [no launch on record, the February 2026 nationwide target having passed](#), with accreditation of service providers still under way. The capability is now [described instead as a component of the September 2026 identity card](#) — a target absorbed into another target.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Windhoek's council [adopted a ten-year smart-city strategy on 15 June, handed over with UN-Habitat and a United Nations cities accelerator](#). The named projects are commercialisation of the city's own fibre network as a digital backbone and a proposed commuter rail linking Windhoek, Katutura and Rehoboth. No funding requirement, implementation timetable or institutional owner is published, and the [Chinese contribution to the pilot drew a parliamentary question about who controls the data](#).

Technology

AI

The month's artificial-intelligence work is language work. The development programme's account of 13 August records [an indigenous-language voice-data repository being built through its AI sprint with the national science and technology university](#). No language count, corpus size, licence or release date is stated, and the question a speech corpus raises above all others — who owns the recorded voices, and on what terms they may train a model — is not addressed in the account.

The state's own first artificial-intelligence contract asks the same question of a different dataset, and answers part of it. A [one-year contract with a United States firm at N\\$39.5m, about US\\$2.4m, introduces satellite imagery, remote sensing and artificial-intelligence monitoring of mahangu, maize, sorghum, cowpea and wheat](#); the agriculture ministry says Namibia retains ownership of the satellite and crop data generated and will receive model and skills transfer. The award drew public objection over transparency and local participation, and no procurement route, tender record or text of the data-ownership and transfer terms is published.

Inclusion

Access to services

The central bank's deputy governor told the payments association's annual general meeting on 28 July that financial inclusion rose from 78% in 2017 to 86% in 2025, and named continued cash reliance, limited rural access, informal-sector barriers and the digital divide as the persistent constraints ([central bank account](#)).

Education added a channel built for the same margins. The education ministry and UNICEF [launched a Namibia Learning Passport, a digital and offline learning platform aimed at rural, remote and underserved young people](#), at the international youth day event in Keetmanshoop. No user target, content catalogue, device requirement or offline distribution route is stated — which matters most for the platform's stated audience, since parliamentary evidence in the same window put schools and clinics in Kavango West as substantially cut off from reliable internet.

What that looks like in one region was put to the parliamentary ICT committee on 11 August: [21 of Kavango West's 188 schools have workable connectivity, leaving 55,002 learners without digital teaching tools](#), and health officials told the same committee that clinics there still struggle with unreliable mobile coverage. The figures are the regional education director's own, and they sit against a target of full telecommunications coverage by 2030.

Data

National statistics

At the inaugural statistics awareness day at Gobabis on 27 July the central bank governor said the identity card presents an opportunity to establish a statistical system enabling secure data matching across administrative databases ([awareness day account](#)), and on 30 July an international statistician told the same event that poor-quality data could weaken public trust and undermine policymaking ([second account](#)).

Open data

The environment ministry put a data platform where the country has no open-data policy at all. Its [Multilateral Environmental Agreements monitoring and reporting platform launched at N\\$12m in the week of 7 August](#), built with UNDP and funded by the Global Environment Facility under a land-governance project, to centralise environmental data for planning, decision-making and national reporting, with the national university as technical and academic partner. No public access, dataset list, licence or publication rule is stated, so on the record held it is a reporting tool rather than open data — and the access-to-information statute that would give a citizen a claim on any of it remains enacted and uncommenced.

A second dataset arrived from outside government altogether. A privately built application [launched nationwide on 14 August taking public reports of more than thirty kinds of infrastructure and service-delivery fault onto a mapped national dataset, with automatic facial and licence-plate redaction](#). It is privately held: no user count, arrangement with any authority, or licence for the data is stated, which is the difference between a dataset and an open one.

Use of satellite data

China [handed over a satellite data-receiving ground station at the earth station outside Windhoek, Namibia's first, receiving remote-sensing data and operated by fourteen trained Namibians](#). The handover date is inferred from a weekday named in a report published the next day, and no operating agreement, data-sharing term or ownership arrangement is held.

Geopolitics

China activities

The President met a vendor's executives in Shenzhen on 7 July and urged the company to create artificial-intelligence jobs and skills for Namibians; the Presidency acknowledged a Chinese contribution of CNY 98,000,000 to the Windhoek smart-city pilot, given by the source as about US\$14.4m in 2026 ([Presidency account](#)).

India activities

[A five-node high-performance computing cluster is specified for deployment at the science and technology university in Windhoek — 17.7 TF peak, 5,320 cores, 480 GB memory and 100 TB of storage](#) under the India-Namibia centre of excellence. No operator, cost or opening date is published. It is a university research cluster and not the national high-performance computing facility the gaps register still seeks; the source itself warns against conflating the two.

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